

Psychogeography, Détournement, Cyberspace

Author(s): Amy J. Elias

Source: *New Literary History*, AUTUMN 2010, Vol. 41, No. 4, What Is an Avant-Garde? (AUTUMN 2010), pp. 821-845

Published by: The Johns Hopkins University Press

Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/23012708

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at https://about.jstor.org/terms



The Johns Hopkins University Press is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *New Literary History*

This content downloaded from 160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Psychogeography, *Détournement*, Cyberspace

Amy J. Elias

DIFFERENT BOTH FROM THE MODERNIST avant-gardes that preceded it and later avant-gardes such as Fluxus and Pop, though "very much in the spirit of Dada and Surrealism, whose project of merging art and life it sought to realize in practice," the Situationist Internationale (SI) flourished between 1957 and 1972 as a consortium of avant-garde organizations (including Cobra, the Lettrist International, the International Movement for an Imaginist Bauhaus, and the London Psychogeographical Committee). Articulated most notably by Guy Debord and Raoul Vaneigem, the SI sought a utopian, revitalized urban life that could both elude the aesthetic tyranny of spectacularized global capitalism and provide a vital, liberatory mode of urban Being.[1] Sadie Plant notes that Georg Lukács had a great influence on Debord, and one can see the influence of Theodor Adorno, Max Horkheimer, and Walter Benjamin as well: permeating all of the SI writings are central Marxist and Frankfurt School concepts such as alienation under capitalism, the culture industry, and commodity fetishism. To combat the false consciousness that he argued produces both alienation and impoverished thought under capitalism, Debord (and others such as Asger Jörn) called for the construction of a new, liberatory urban space. For the early SI, "psychogeography"—the "study of the precise laws and specific effects of the geographical environment . . . on the emotions and behaviour of individuals"—became central to the emancipation of the human psyche.[2]

Today, theoretically informed advocates and devotees of the Internet and Web 2.0 often draw correspondences between the SI's redefinition of city space and the redefinition of cosmopolitan space currently taking place in virtual realities. It is true, of course, that hacker and libertarian manifestoes have often couched utopian ideals within cyberspace rhetoric: cybercultures sometimes adopt the term "psychogeography" to describe what happens when one travels through the World Wide Webb (WWW) landscape, applying SI concepts to the entirety of virtual space on the web. Hacker cultures and the blogosphere like to extol an anarchic, liberationist potential within the WWW:[3] they frequently define it as a dematerialized, telematic space central to the purest form of

New Literary History, 2010, 41: 821–845

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

algorithmically defined movement, transitivity, and libidinal investment. Scores of web writers seem to have discovered that Debord's description of *dérive*—an urban walking journey—sounds a lot like web surfing:

> In a dérive one or more persons during a certain period drop their usual motives for movement and action, their relations, their work and leisure activities, and let themselves be drawn by the attractions of the terrain and the encounters they find there. The element of chance is less determinant than one might think: from the dérive point of view cities have a psychogeographical relief, with constant currents, fixed points and vortexes which strongly discourage entry into or exit from certain zones.[4]

The dérive is always urban in location and character, just as the web implies a kind of cosmopolitanism. The spatial field of the web surfer may be either delimited according to search parameters or openly processual according to linked pathways, and so too, the spatial field of the dérive "may be precisely delimited or vague, depending on whether the activity is aimed at studying a terrain or at emotional disorientation" (24). The spatial field of the dérive "presupposes the determining of bases and the calculation of directions of penetration"—what in cyberspace we call links.

Yet to claim that cyberspace taken in its entirety is the new space of dérive is at best tautological: in many instances, cyberspace consciously *models* itself on the notions of dérive and psychogeography articulated by the SI.[5] Moreover, correspondences between SI concepts and the WWW as an entity are usually metaphorical rather than substantive. If anything, the web is increasingly part of the spectacle rather than a challenge to it. Like the postmodern city, the WWW has become naturalized as a dehumanized space of commerce, work, and diversionary entertainment; like urban territory, it now cordons off "neighborhoods" and gated communities that effectively limit wandering. Increasingly, even at the level of the personal website, its aesthetics are submitting to the rhetorical and graphics-design clichés of corporate advertising. The ephemerality that constitutes the political efficacy of the situation as defined by SI, moreover, is illusory on the web: what "feels" ephemeral to someone surfing through sites is actually a passage through sometimes permanent, always preconstructed, and maintained databases and uploaded files. Importantly, as insiders such as Lawrence Lessig have repeatedly pointed out, while the numbers of Web surveillance techniques now practiced by agencies seeking to preempt global terrorism is indeterminate, certainly URLs, port numbers, and IP addresses are instant locators that undermine the anonymity central to the street protest. It is also increasingly common for search engines such as Google to tailor programs to search

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

parameters deemed acceptable to specific political environments and nation-states: the web, in contrast to the SI in any form, is increasingly submitting information access to the demands of totalitarian politics. Finally, there is the problem of motivation. For the SI, "situations" were not random acts; they were constructed interventions with organized aesthetic aims and political rationale. The web as a whole cannot be said to have any kind of rationale or logic of this kind.

But there *are* web-based practices that seem congenial to a Debordian aesthetics, and these demand a more rigorous consideration of how Web 2.0 might facilitate and revitalize the intervention of the *arts* in culture in the manner of the SI. Today, sometimes at the risk of surveillance and political blowback, some cyberartists are redefining (and extending into new territories) key concepts of the 1960s Situationist avant-garde. While the SI provided a vocabulary of resistance to the capitalist spectacle and a praxis for reconnecting art to life and reenergizing aesthetics in the material sphere of the urban city, cyberspace art attempts to work in the belly of the beast—to rehumanize and politicize the absolutely nonmaterial virtual space that itself was birthed by the military-industrial complex of the 1950s. Sites protesting the commercialization and spectacularization of the Web are poetic interventions—stoppages and delays on the information highway that force observation and contemplation. In the manner of situations, they construct a momentary stay against the tsunami of functionalist, alienating, or dehumanizing images flooding the (web surfer's) perceptual screen. An avant-garde counterculture is emerging on the web that takes as its starting point, in the manner of the SI, an attack on spectacular *aesthetics* in the interest of intellectual emancipation. New postconvergence media arts now extend SI concepts into new, dematerialized territories. In the following discussion, I will identify SI aims and principles that seem central to this new media art and examine some specific examples of net.art, Flash art, and Situationist-inspired art in Second Life® to illustrate how it might be understood within the theoretical terrain of psychogeography and situation. My aim is to contextualize the cyberarts within a Situationist effort to revitalize human experience, ironically from within its most spectacular creation.

Situation, Psychogeography, and Détourned Play

In one of the founding documents of the SI, Debord wrote, "Our central idea is the construction of situations, that is to say, the concrete construction of momentary ambiances of life and their transformation into a superior passional quality."[6] The situation (an "integrated ensemble

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

of behavior in time") was a planned intervention conceived as "the opposite of works of art,"[7] because as an ephemeral staging of human activity that "contains its own negation and moves inevitably toward its own reversal,"[8] it valorized and preserved nothing. A situation could be the iconoclastic defamation of public monuments with anticapitalist graffiti; a twenty-four-hour papering of the city in oracular poster art; the organized inscription of poetic or plastic art into the functionalist space of the city proper—virtually any activity that refocused the glazed eyes of the bourgeois populace and unleashed an awakened, passionate reconnection with the real.

The situation was made possible by dérive and *détournement.* As already noted, dérive is a kind of walk through urban space that evinces a "will to playful creation" and "the practice of a passional journey out of the ordinary through a rapid changing of ambiances."[9] Debord defines dérive as a "drifting," a person's transient passage through environments; it entailed "playful constructive behavior . . . which completely distinguished it from the classical notions of the journey and the stroll." Dérive prepared the way for a "life in step with desire, and the concrete representation of such a life."[10] What was sought in this movement through urban space was authentic pleasure, not the manufactured desire of the spectacle. Yet significantly, this pleasure was created not through random meandering through city space but through movement dictated by simple algorithms—"Go Left, Go Left, Go Right"—that curtailed randomness without prescribing exact or motivated direction. Following the algorithm in a dérive through the city, one would encounter the unexpected and be forced to view one's surroundings in a new way.

While dérive described a phenomenology, détournement described a hermeneutics and a praxis. Détournement was "the reuse of preexisting artistic elements in a new ensemble,"[11] what postmodernism would come to understand as a deliberate, politicized use of irony and pastiche. It was a method of interpretation and reinterpretation: reordering preexisting materials in order to expose their banality or their function within a system of spectacular control and creatively reconstructing them in the service of authenticity. Détournement, therefore, was a mirroring of capitalist recuperation—spectacle's perpetual reintegration and redefinition of existing social elements—but was intended to have opposite effects. Instead of naturalizing existing reality, it denaturalized and parodied it to expose and counter alienation.

There are two points to be made here. First, the concepts of dérive and détournement illustrate how *play* for the SI took on a poststructuralist, antilogocentric quality, for it meant both the free play of the imagination *and* the overturning of closed logical categories associated with the

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

spectacle and ideological master narratives. However, as it was for both the early-modern baroque and for later groups such as Oulipo, play for the SI was also constrained and *rational*. An example is the algorithmically structured dérive: "Ordinary life, previously conditioned by the problem of survival, can be dominated rationally. . . . and play, radically broken from a confined ludic time and space, must invade the whole of life."[12] Against fake cities of play such as Caribbean tourist islands and Las Vegas would stand a real city of play, a "renovated cartography" that was ordered by logic but could "express not subordination to randomness but complete *insubordination* to habitual influences." Second, the situation constructed by dérive and détournement resituated participants in a renewed, libidinal *space*. Reinventing physical space was the means to reinventing leisure, but it was also the means to renewing perception (from its "subordination to habitual influences") and thus radically challenging the alienation and *boredom* generated by the capitalist spectacle.[13]

Renewed or defamiliarized spaces call for new maps. Artists needed to intervene in the production of space by creating new mapping structures. Thus was "psychogeography" born. Psychogeography was SI's anarchic mapping practice that wrested perceptual control from the panoptic spectacle and returned it to the human body. It produced all kinds of somatic mappings—emotional mappings produced through dérive, sense maps that détourned visuality (maps based upon smells, sounds, touch instead of sight), and maps not corresponding to real space (such as those produced by overlaying maps of two different regions). For Debord, psychogeography was linked to a new form of critique that could be ephemeral enough to avoid recuperation but powerful enough to challenge alienation: "By virtue of the resulting mobile space of play, and by virtue of freely chosen variations in the rules of the game, the independence of places will be rediscovered without any new exclusive tie to the soil, and thus too the authentic *journey* will be restored to us, along with authentic life."[14] Movement and passion combined in the respatialized body. The body-as-commodity was removed from the abstract nowhere of the spectacle and redefined—resituated, glowing with life, in the city of ephemerality, movement, somatic perception, and desire.

The legacy of the SI has lived on in "real life" artistic projects predicated on its original writings and goals. One of the most interesting of these, originally sponsored by Glowlab, is the annual New York City Conflux festival, which features projects integrating the Situationist "classical" approach to psychogeography as well as "emerging artistic, conceptual, and technology-based practices." At Conflux, the "city becomes a playground, a laboratory and a space for civic action in the development of new networks and communities."[15] The now de rigueur phenomena

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

of "flash mobs"—the planned and/or spontaneous use of text messaging to gather groups for political or absurdist activities—also derives directly from Situationist models. Moreover, there are now pop culture and mainstream adaptations of SI ideas. One can find the term "psychogeography" in *Wikipedia* these days, linked to a number of websites for conferences, organizations, and meetings that promote urban tourism and exploration. As "Barnaby Snap of Helsinki" writes at socialfiction.org (itself a site constructed in the spirit of the SI), "it was fun in the beginning but now it's just everywhere . . . psychogeography has turned into the Dolce & Gabbana of the pedestrian underground."[16] Many cities now provide technology at visitors centers for "psychogeography" as a tourism activity that allows city visitors to use GPS or alternative mapping to tour through a city's prefabricated (often simulated) and heavily marketed historical and "cultural" attractions.

Heirs of the SI are still with us—the aggressively political "precariat" movement in Europe (with its saint San Precario), work by "hoaxes" artists (for example, Beauvais Lyons), and interventionist art by activists such as the "Serpica Naro," the Molleindustria, Guerriglia Marketing, and Yes Men groups.[17] Yet ironically, in the face of the co-optation of Situationist ideas by the culture industry, it may be that the SI's concepts of situation, dérive, and psychogeography are also instantiated these days online, defined through specific websites utilizing Flash, Java, and other applications. At these sites, anarchic impulses are presented as a détournement of official public information. E-zines, blogs, chat rooms, and other elements of web culture have the potential to détourn spectacular ideological constructions. However, at most of these sites, the vehicle is usually satire without poetic intent. In other words, few of these sites combine a poetics, a hermeneutics, a phenomenology, and a politics in the manner of the SI's "situation."

More important, for my purposes, are sites that attempt a *poetical* détournement of web rationality: sites that détourn the web itself, understood as a spectacular creation that turns bodies into alienated desiring machines in the interest of functional rationality for the sake of commodity consumption. Sites, that is, that construct a virtual totality that mimics Raoul Vaneigem's desire: "What do I want? Not a succession of moments, but one huge instant. A totality that is lived and without the experience of 'time passing.' The feeling of 'time passing' is simply the feeling of growing old. And yet . . . virtual moments, possibilities, are necessarily rooted in that time. To federate moments, to bring out the pleasure in them, to release their promise of life is already to be learning how to construct a 'situation.'"[18] "Virtual moments" here construct libidinal time leading to a "federated whole" rather than a closed and

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

permanent system. The quote is striking when read today, for it is precisely in the context of a Web 2.0 integrated reality that we see the possible, if virtual, realization of Vaneigem's desire. In what ways do some websites "federate moments" to create the lived poetics of the "situation"?

Dérive, détournement, et le virtuel

Given the scope of the web and the frenetic pace of site creation (and obsolescence), it is difficult in the present format to convey fully the specific qualities of the artists and sites that serve as examples of Situationist psychogeography and dérive. And that's the point: one needs to experience these places in order to feel their affective and poetic power.

One site type that seems akin in spirit and function to Situationism and psychogeography is net-art (alternatively, net.art and netart), aimed at defamiliarizing space and reconnecting it to human desire. These art sites attack spectacular alienation, constructed through the reduction of human desires to functional subjectivities.[19] That is, they create spaces that are "algorithmically" predetermined but situated randomly in the cosmopolitan space of the web. Creating Situationist sites in the cybersoul of the spectacle both détournes the notion of the web as functionalist "information highway" and creates a space for the free play of imagination and desire beyond simple surfing, movement, and transitivity. As noted by one critic:

> Net.art, by which is meant art written in HTML (and now, optionally, in Macromedia Flash) and exhibited for the first time on the Web, is in many ways the antithesis of museum-gallery art: it has no originals; in many cases its maker's name is a pseudonym; it is accessible from anywhere on the Web; it is rarely dated and it rarely restricts reproduction and duplication under copyright legislation. It is always on exhibit, but it may disappear one day without a trace. In the world of art objects, it is an anti-commodity, and it is hard to imagine how anyone could profit from its sale.[20]

Because of the confluence of media technologies and the plastic arts these days, these sites look and operate much like gallery media art. However, their placement on (and often design for) the web creates synergies between them and SI projects that are often eclipsed in gallery art, always reified by the space of its exhibition.

Net-art websites are both potentially infinite and extremely ephemeral, though some sites have now been online so long as to become "canonical." For example, the German artist Alba D'Urbano was one of the first artists to move her art to the Internet; her site *Couture* is a

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

feminist parody of the fashion industry and was developed by Nicolas Reichelt, whose own work in Flash and other technologies includes 3-D landscapes of the Institute of New Media in Frankfurt and an amusing 1991 animation *The Monument to Nothing*.[21] Another "classic" site is Marika Dermineur and Stéphane Degoutin's *Keyboard*, a visual and aural interactive site that forces contemplation of the act of communication between people. Their artists' statement describes the project as "About language, ... about articulated gestures, about text, code, protocols, automation, about keyboards as primitive interface, as space, orientation, inscription, sign, memory, passage." On entering the site, one is immediately ordered to "write something," and after typing in some word or phrase, the viewer sees a video stream of a woman's face saying the letters and then pronouncing the word. The point here is the breaking of boundaries between human and technology, outside and inside, body and machine, words and sounds, words and desire for communication. At Dermineur, Degoutin, and Gwenola Wagon's *What Are You?* the focus of attack—through a random association of words, images, and music generated by user clicks—is the false "newness" and arbitrary categories of identity generated by market consumerism. The site combines music, randomly selected pairs of search keywords (such as "junkie/toxic," "top model/macho" or "cannibal/New York") and images captured from the web with similar keyword titles. Algorithmically timing how these pairings of word and picture are flashed on the screen, the site creates startling images and sometimes eerie juxtapositions.

As the site creators note, "In spite of huge investments, designers, marketing experts and trend hunters produce only two new trends a year. *What Are You?*, thanks to its database of more than 500 past, present and future trends, generates instantly 250.000 combinations, by randomely [sic] associating keywords. It is therefore in the position to produce the trends for the next 125,000 years (i.e. until 127005)."[22] Ironically participating in "trendspotting," the site aims to exhaust it, using algorithmic randomness to critique web space as the space of consumption. But also in the manner of poetry, the split screen startles the web surfer with unexpected combinations of signs.[23]

In a different vein, Beth Stryker's and Sawad Brooks's net.art projects confront a passive surfer with the political nature of offline material landscape, and territory through an online human mapping project. *DissemiNET* is a Java-based net.art project commissioned in part by the Wexner Center for the Arts and part of the Walker Art Center's Digital Studies Collection.[24] It was begun with a set of testimonies, "cases with Probusqueda de Los Ninos in El Salvador, where stories of disappearances and displacements have accumulated in the wake of a 12 year

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

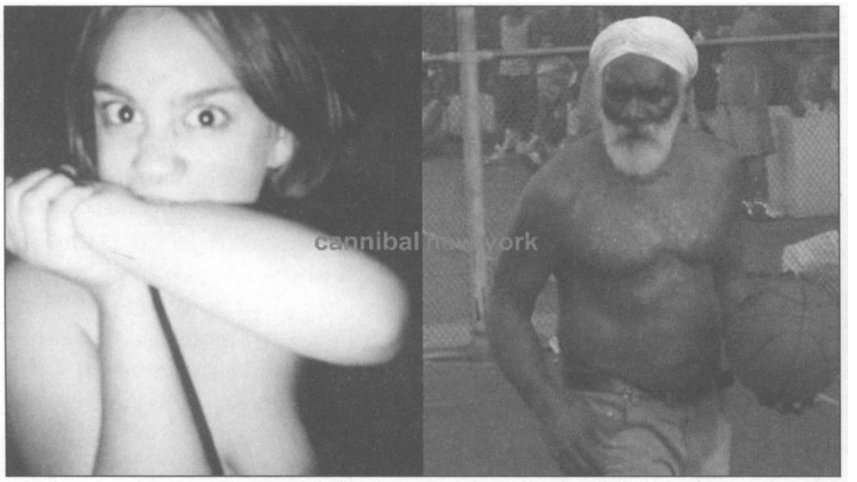


Fig.1. Screenshot from Dermineur, Degoutin, and Wagon's *What Are You?* April 2010

civil war."[25] The interactive site collects testimonies of homelessness, diaspora, and global dispersal and arranges them by keywords such as "belong," "daughter," "crossroads," "exile." According to the Walker Center's site, DissemiNET uses "fuzzy logic" to "algorithmically create a cyber-palimpsest of related memories"; it functions "on a boundary between identity (i.e. national and personal) and its dispersal over the web," and creates "a cross-linked, communal storytelling space."[26] The project correlates the diasporic nature of online existence with the real, lived, politicized diasporas of people throughout the world. Its virtual space thus functions almost precisely as an online dérive, reconfiguring material space as human space, lived space, and storied space. Another Stryker/Brooks project, *Radarweb*, presents information about the U.S. occupation of Okinawa. *DissemiNET* and *Radarweb* are both situation-like interventions protesting dehumanization in different political contexts by specifically linking web space with lived urban space: the authors write that they "envisioned the stories which would be deposited in this space as tales of errancy, recollections of being lost, searching for others, experiencing displacement."[27] Displacement, errancy, lostness, searching—these are precisely the strategy of the dérive. The displacement figured, however, is not voluntary; encountering the site, a web surfer is put into the uncomfortable position of negotiating a reterritorialized space, mapped via human stories of exile and forced displacements.[28]

Net-art is increasingly bringing together online and museum spaces, for as with Stryker and Brooks's projects, artworks are often exhibited in both venues simultaneously. Quickly gaining prominence in this

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

regard, Young-Hae Chang Heavy Industries (YHCHI) constructs short narrative artworks found primarily on the WWW, though also exhibited in major museum galleries internationally. Narratives appear on the screen in animated Flash sentence, phrase, or word units, accompanied by an instrumental soundtrack (usually jazz) and color screens. As N. Katherine Hayles notes, each of YHCHI's texts is a multimodal unit of sound, typeface, Flash animation, and color. In not only *Nippon*, which she discusses at length, but all of YHCHI's texts, "if the space of the text has been temporalized, it has also been reinforced as a semiotic system demanding deep attention."[29] "Deep attention" was precisely the goal of the SI, and Jessica Pressman is correct to see these texts as a second- or third-generation digital art that has now moved into the domain of self-critique. I would add that critique of lived space—in this case, virtual space—is also the texts' link to SI activities.[30]

For example, Pressman has nicely illustrated how this project is an example of what she calls "digital modernism" within a fluidly defined high modernist aesthetic that is actually closer to a "post-postmodernism." I would focus less on the period markers and emphasize instead how, in the manner of Fluxus happenings, irony and a Pop aesthetic characterize YHCHI's texts. Indeed, the climax of *Dakota*—a short "road novel"—occurs when the narrator encounters Elvis Presley and when Marilyn Monroe appears as an icon: Warhol's Pop images and aesthetic everywhere inform this and other YHCHI texts, including their use of techniques drawn from graphic design and advertising. YHCHI's texts may reference Marcel Duchamp and Ezra Pound (Young-Hae Chang apparently wrote a Ph.D. dissertation on Duchamp and has cited him as an inspiration[31]), but *The Art of Sleep* (2006) makes the point that Duchamp sold out to the very art culture he critiqued. YHCHI's pieces are chatty, profane, and colloquial, while simultaneously incorporating references to critical theory and high art; they work like cinema, but they also refuse modernist film's symbolic imagery as well as its seriousness and utopianism. They are often self-reflexively ironic. *The Art of Silence*, an online "interview" between Young-Hae Chang, Marc Voge, and Jemima Rellie, for example, is a piece that mimics a serious art journal interview. Here, however, interviewees' "voices" are recorded as digital sound bites and strung together by computer to form sentences and an amusing conversation scenario, in which Young-Hae Chang and Marc Voge end up yelling "bullshit" at one another and admitting to knowing nothing about art.

In *The Art of Sleep*, a first-person insomniac rails against the commercialism and tyranny of art institutions, delivering a Dadaist statement about art ("Art is Everything" and "Art is Dead! Long live Art!"). But by the end of the piece the speaker bemoans the night's loss of sleep because

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

s/he has to "get up early to start the Tate Commission." Overall the pieces are more Donald Barthelme than Pound, illustrating the thesis of Jorge Luis Borges' "Pierre Menard, Author of the Quixote" that if we try to do modernism now, we get something slightly askew from the original, tinged with irony because of its location in a particular post-WWII, post-WWW chronotope.

Given their exhibition location on the Internet, these pieces work like frenetic digital billboards constructed by a smart-ass nonprofit or a beatnik wannabe; they are signpostings of high art that stop one short on the digital highway but that also use irony to undercut seriousness, utopianism, and high-art pretension. Unlike market websites, they have no profit motive; unlike museum sites that often showcase exhibits online, they deflate the prestige and seriousness of installation art and are online all the time, *en entier*. The flashing text, linearity of story, and irony keep this moment from becoming sublime, fetishized, or commercialized. The texts present political messages but are laced with banal humor, profanity, or overt sexual terminology in the manner of everyday speech. They enact a Situationist "utopian anti-utopianism," and are texts that mock simultaneously the pretentions of academic "hypertext fiction" and the banality of the commercial website. In an interview, Young-Hae Chang notes, "We can't and won't help readers to 'locate' us. Distance, homelessness, anonymity, and insignificance are all part of the Internet literary voice, and we welcome them."[32] YHCHI's texts valorize and preserve nothing; they stage human activity—art as a momentary ambiance of life.

New Internet art is being created all the time, and there are now websites and university-sponsored programs dedicated to net-art. Currently organizations such as Turbulence.org and the Electronic Literature Organization provide major funding for new net.art projects.[33] Countering generally accepted assumptions that the WWW is a medium catering to business and entertainment industries, much of this visual art furthers the reach of Situationism and psychogeography into the virtual space of the World Wide Web, offering new ways that aesthetic defamiliarization and poetic détournement may spatialize and release the pleasure of federated moments of time.

A Second Life® for Psychogeography and *Dérive*

I have been arguing that the World Wide Web should be seen in very specific instances as an analogue to real urban space that provides new opportunities for détournement and dérive. But one might also conceive of today's virtual-reality worlds and massively multiplayer online

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

roleplaying games (MMORPGs) as visual performance sites that offer new real-time opportunities for urban situationism and psychogeography.[34] Certainly, this conception applies to a virtual world such as Second Life®. A 3-D virtual reality based in San Francisco and created in 1999 by Philip Rosedale, Second Life® was modeled on the "Metaverse" in Neal Stephenson's cyberpunk novel *Snow Crash* and is a real-time virtual life-world.[35] Running on Linden servers but on a global grid, its landscapes and objects are constructed by its "residents" who appear in-world as avatars and socialize on digital "islands" that are privately or corporately rented. There are no game objectives in Second Life®, no scoring or game parameters. "Land" is for sale and can be developed according to its residents' desires and programming/building skills, and residents construct communities fitting their own social needs.[36]

Because Second Life® is a virtual reality owned by a corporation but "built" independently by residents, its fundamental characteristic is paradox: the first-born of Spectacle, its virtual landscapes nonetheless offer some residents opportunities for Situationist interventions into, and commentaries upon, both this virtual world and the practices structuring everyday life. Most people use Second Life® in order to replicate real life; the world is known for its merchandizing and sex sites, and much of the world's social interaction and architecture is astonishingly banal. Yet others are using the space creatively, taking advantage of the fact that, unlike many MMORPGs, in which players work with preset character and environmental options, Second Life® offers individuals the opportunity to build and define their own environments from scratch. There now exist wonderful teaching and research sites in Second Life®, such as Bryan Carter's "Virtual Harlem," that are making use of these capacities and extending educational possibilities into virtual space.[37] In addition, some creative artists have used the virtual world to create psychogeographical landscapes and moments of détournement that work in two directions: inward, toward the virtual world of Second Life® itself, and outward, to the world of "real spectacle" that constitutes the consensus reality of web users.

For example, understood through "common sense" perception, the virtual constructs in Second Life® appear as "architecture." As such, in this world, buildings have the potential to defy natural laws and, through their very shape, materials, and location, to be imbued with affect and dreamscape desire. Doesinger notes of SL architectures that any "game" elements inhering to Second Life® are actually about this space, its construction and narrativization. The world "is about 'playing at architectures' and 'playing at communication,'" and the architectural modeling that is possible in Second Life® may be having an impact on real-world architectural thinking.[38] Floating unsupported in midair, their

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

contorted or symbolic structures defying laws of natural physics, the most ambitious cityscapes in Second Life® can illustrate the utopianism of situationism's "Unitary Urbanism," in which unique, dynamic "experimental cities" would create an "ambiance" or "atmospheric effect"—an emotional effect or response linked to a "gesture." In "Formulary for a New Urbanism," Gilles Ivain describes the new city as if it were one of Marco Polo's imagined, invisible cities in Italo Calvino's novel:[39]

> Buildings charged with evocative power, symbolic edifices representing desires, forces, events past, present and to come. . . . Everyone will be in his own personal "cathedral," so to speak. There will be rooms more conducive to dreams than any drug, and houses where one cannot help but love. Others will be irresistibly alluring to travelers. . . . The districts of this city could correspond to the whole spectrum of diverse feelings that one encounters by chance in everyday life. . . . Bizarre Quarter—Happy Quarter . . —Noble and Tragic Quarter. . . . The principal activity of the inhabitants will be the CONTINUOUS DÉRIVE. The changing of landscapes from one hour to the next will result in complete disorientation.[40]

Similarly, in Second Life®, architects and artists are modeling new "sense landscapes" that attempt, through the use of sound and visual effects, to create an actual experience of symbolic and atmospheric architectures. Those involved with international initiatives such as the Odyssey Art Simulator and the Virtual Arts Initiative are serious artists who believe "that virtual worlds . . . provide the opportunity, in the form of a new technology, for radically innovative forms of aesthetic expression."[41]

In this regard, "Seventeen Unsung Songs" by Adam Nash, a member of the Virtual Arts Initiative, straddles the line between digital media, architecture, and "land art," involving dérive in the interest of a unity urbanism within the nonmaterial space of Second Life®. The project installed seventeen sculptures (Unsung Songs) at East of Odyssey, Odyssey Art Simulator in Second Life®, an "island" collective that hosts arts galleries, new installations, and performance sites. It was also a winning project in the First Architecture and Design Competition in Second Life® and won the 2008 National Art Award in New Media at the Queensland Gallery of Modern Art.[42] All of the seventeen "sculptures"—architecturally complex and involving sound, color, and light effects—involve avatars in some form of interactive play. As Lisa Dethridge notes, "These fascinating kinetic devices invite us to linger and play while probing the role of the avatar within the complex 3D space. Each Unsong Song is like the product of an ethereal instrument, fresh from another planet where synaesthesia is the dominant mode."[43] A few of the pieces are still on exhibit at Odyssey, and one, "Unsung Song #7:

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Moaning Columns of Longing," illustrates the combination of desire, interactivity, and sense appeals in some of these sculptures. "Unsung Song #7" presents a platform on which eleven tubular columns sway and wiggle in the breeze. It instructs a visiting avatar to approach, which

> will spawn a Moaning Column of Longing that loves only you. [. . .] Once it is spawned, it is waiting for you to return to touch it. Every hour that you don't come back, it will get a little duller and a little smaller. It will start moaning a little louder. After the 12th hour of loneliness, the moaning will start to get quieter. It will IM you every 3 hours to tell you it loves you and wants to see you. If you don't touch within 24 hours, it will die of loneliness and a broken heart. And it will be your fault.

The column's script continues to run whether the avatar is present or not. Dethridge has called this a "giggly theatre of cruelty," but from the position of the Second Life® user is also a multimedia symbolic edifice representing desires in the manner of unitary urbanism. In a set with the other sculptures in "Seventeen Unsung Songs," this piece constructs an interactive landscape that sharpens dulled perception, forcing literal connection and sympathy between an avatar and the "inanimate" creations that populate its lifeworld.

However, as a digital artist Nash himself does not perceive Second Life® as do most Second Life® users, who tend to perceive his work as "architecture," for this would require one to define Second Life® as material rather than analogical space. In its most material aspects, this environment is after all the instantiation of a mathematical concept, "realized in digital form." It is a realtime 3D multiuser virtual environment (RT3D MUVE) in which multiple media interact to create affect. Different media principles, including artificial intelligence, converge in this space to the ends of producing affect and meaning through representation—in this case of "architecture" and "land." What Nash says he has produced is art in a virtual postconvergence medium.[44] It is important to note this difference in space perception between amateur users and artist-programmers in these kinds of virtual worlds: while analogies to SI concepts such as "unitary urbanism" may be useful in terms of "reader/user response" theories, Nash indicates that the concepts can have only a metaphorical relation to the actual art practices located there. Yet while Nash's work is a redefinition of space beyond anything that the SI conceived, it is essentially in line with the SI's advocacy of a "space" that was dematerialized to the extent that it enabled affect to operate against the anesthetic effects of the spectacle.

A different and much more materialist project with overt psychogeographical resonances juxtaposes space inside Second Life® to space

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

outside it, whether the everyday world of consensus reality or the more rarified space of the real-world art gallery. For example, John Craig Freeman's project "Imaging Place," a collaboration with critical theorist Greg Ulmer and the Florida Research Ensemble, has three locations: it is a project located on the WWW, it is an installation in galleries and museums, and it is built as interactive architecture in Second Life®, currently floating in the air above Emerson Island (owned by Emerson College).[45] The project defines its psychogeographical aims through a combination of Situationist ideas, Greek poetics, *I-Ching* philosophy, and Ulmer's synthesis of *Applied Grammatology* to create "a place-based virtual reality project that combines panoramic video, and three-dimensional virtual worlds to document situations where the forces of globalization are impacting the lives of individuals in local communities."[46] Freeman and Ulmer have constructed a theoretical vocabulary to describe the connections between place, storytelling, memory, mood, and political context in these scenes: their method is called "choramancy" (incorporating the notion of choral voices and Platonic chora, and related to geomancy), which works through "Mystory" with the aim of "divination," a revealing of how and what reality is at a given moment in time. Ulmer has directly correlated the aims of the project with those of the Situationists, noting that "The SI tested possibilities of traversing the city form following not conventional maps but the hubs of mood. [A] possibility tested in 'Imaging Place' is the capacity of atmospheres to sustain moods, and these in turn function as attractors of attention and focus, with important implications for ethics and politics of cyberspace. Second Life®® provides ideal conditions for testing mood as primary interface."[47]

In "Imaging Beijing," presented as part of Turbulence.org's "Mixed Realities" project, Freeman notes, "The mood of the movement from Xizhimen Station to the demolition zone was framed by mourning the loss of ancient cultural heritage on the one hand, and optimism for a brighter more livable future on the other, simultaneous attraction and repulsion. . . . The place was allowed to speak for itself." The Second Life® location is visual and interactive, literalizing in three-dimensional space the layering of maps and discourses that occurs at the website. To access "Imaging Beijing" in Second Life®, an avatar flies up into the sky, landing on a huge round floating disc upon which is imprinted a map of the earth as seen from atmospheric space. Red lines, like laser light strings, project out of this map into the space above it, connecting to other platform satellite images of specific city spaces. Upon these map-platforms sit egg-shaped, metallic-looking pods; once in the pod, one accesses a 360-degree view of that city space and hears audio interviews or conversations with a local resident. An avatar lands on the globe

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

platform, walks a laser tightrope to the Beijing platform, walks into the pods, and experiences an aural and visual "encounter" with a young man from Beijing.[48]

This project links map to mood, a lived human history, to the physicality of place, and connects both to larger political and social constructs such as government and international policies. The effect of visiting the Second Life® installation and going through all of the pods on one platform is one of temporary saturation or immersion in, but also of an unsettling sense of unfamiliarity with, place, very unlike the reassuring familiarity given by tourism. Debord wrote that "basically tourism is the chance to go and see what has been made trite, because the economic management of travel to different places suffices in itself to ensure those places' interchangeability."[49] The aim of "Imaging Place" in all of its exhibition formats is clearly to return the specificity of place to space through virtual psychogeography. When asked about the relation between the "Imaging Place" project and Situationism, Freeman noted, "As I understand it the Situationists were developing the idea that moving through space, i.e. the dérive, was an act of reasoning, that thinking itself was spatial in nature. . . . In my work I try to capitalize in the inherent drifting of avatars through a virtual experience by providing the equivalent of the Situationists' *plateau tourné*, the vortex, turntable or hub. I do this with the panoramic imagery which is represented in various iterations of the Imaging Place as the node. The nodes are organized into complex scenes we call chora, which is similar to the zone in psychogeography."[50] But "mood" for Freeman includes that which is induced by social context. He notes that he is increasingly drawn to those places where the forces of globalization are affecting the lives of local communities, places like borders and ports, walls and fences.[51] For his "Imaging the U.S./Mexico Border" project, Freeman traveled to the U.S./Mexico Border region at Tijuana and San Ysidro, producing in roughly a week the fieldwork media needed to complete the project. He notes at the project website that "There are three public issues I am exploring. . . . First is the contradictions and bigotry of U.S. Immigration policy toward Latin America. Second is the labor and environmental exploitations of North American Free Trade Agreement, and the third is global human trafficking, slave and indentured labor, and the sex industry."[52] The installation is available now at the Second Life®, Emerson Island location, but it opened on January 5, 2007 at Ars Virtua, one of the premier art galleries in Second Life®.[53]

If these Second Life® projects illustrate how situationist psychogeography and dérive have moved into virtual space, then others illustrate how constructed situations based on détournement can be a central aim of much virtual art. A small example of Second Life® détournement

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

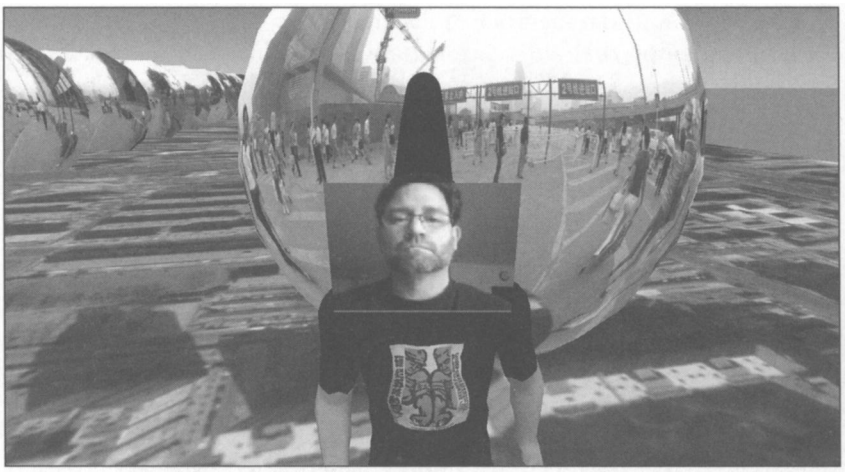


Fig.2. John Craig Freeman, "Imaging Beijing," in Second Life

was the hacker-programmed "bombing" of ABC, the island of the Australian Broadcasting Network (at the time the third largest commercial site at Second Life®), which incapacitated the island and changed its landscape to a bomb-craterscape.[54] The "griefing" by anonymous attackers was particularly interesting in that the "bombs," or at least their fuselage, apparently were in the shape of Nike and Puma logos. Even if not intended this way, the attack managed to take a form reminiscent of Situationist spontaneity, anonymity, and anticorporate/anticapitalist politics, ironically détourning media images within the context of urban play. Other hacker-inspired activities in Second Life®, often termed "malicious play" or outright sabotage, similarly mimic the poetics of détournment. One example is the deliberate creation of "grey goo," self-replicating object scripts that demand increasing server attention, in essence shutting down a system while concentrating on replicating an object ad infinitum. ("Grey goo" is a term from nanotechnology and science fiction describing an apocalypse scenario where self-replicating robots take over the earth.) Second Life® famously suffered a grey-goo attack in September of 2006, when huge floating Super Marios appeared on numerous islands and started replicating, eventually locking up the grid. The object of the anonymous attacker may have been malicious play or arrogant techno-display, but the form of the attack—programming a popular game figure icon to shut down a game world increasingly defined by capitalist imperatives—was right up the Situationist alley, and grey goo has in fact been deployed to aesthetic ends in work by Second Life® performance artist Gazira Babeli.

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Babeli is now also a member of Second Front, a Second Life® performance art troupe that aims to enact Situationist principles, aesthetics, and politics, particularly in the form of détournement. Formed in 2006 with eight members who took their influence "from numerous sources, including Dada, Fluxus, Futurist Syntesi, the Situationist International and contemporary performance artists like Laurie Anderson and Guillermo Gomez-Pena," the group creates "theatres of the absurd that challenge notions of virtual embodiment, online performance and the formation of virtual narrative."[55] Second Front is performance-based, operating in real time in virtual space. Early on, the troupe staged absurdist performance happenings and interventions in Second Life®, generally confronting the virtual world's increasing mirroring of real-life bourgeois mundanity and commercialism. One early performance, for example, was at Reuters News Agency Island inworld, where the group staged an all-text performance improv called "BREAKING NEWS." As described by Man Machinaga in a *Rhizome* interview with Domenico Quaranta, "Breaking News was an absurdist play on the 18th Century idea of the Town Crier, played out in the latest of 21st Century news facilities. By shouting out non-sequitur, moment-to-moment headlines, Second Front hoped to perhaps jam the usual flow of information in the Reuters space."[56] Second Front have staged a commentary on celebrity at Columbia College campus by having one of their (increasingly well-known) members gunned down at a lecture; have taught seemingly genuine Second Life® self-help seminars on "feeling the intoxication of being an avatar," which ended with befuddled conferencees confronting a blood-splattered lecture hall and flaming floor tiles; have disruptively delivered massive amounts of (unasked for) virtual pizzas to a virtual Second Life® board meeting; and have entered combat gamer zones in Second Life® unannounced and wearing peacenik gear "in order to carry out our first official martyrdom operation."[57]

After 2007, the group moved toward scripted performance pieces with an interventionist edge, and the troupe's current members have fundamental ties to SI aesthetics, particularly as these were reformulated by Fluxus in the 1960s.[58] Since 2008 and the more recent reformation of the troupe membership, Second Front's work has the polished quality of gallery or public performance, often being performed not only in the virtual reality of Second Life® but also in real-world galleries, festivals, and event venues such as iMAL (Brussels) and PERFORMA 07 NYC. The group may be moving away from its Situationist roots in the direction of surrealist performance and museum exhibition, though certainly the cornerstones of their aesthetic have remained détournement and remediation.

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Remediation, defined as the refashioning and layering of older media and media references within newer media forms,[59] has come to play a significant role in the group's performance identity and its aesthetic of play. For example, *The Gate*, publically performed in October 4, 2007, was located at Odyssey Art Simulator and featured a video portal between Second Life® and the new Brussels Interactive Media Arts Laboratory (IMAL). *The Gate* was seen simultaneously by real-life audiences in Brussels and avatar audiences at Odyssey.[60] Organized and curated by Yves Bernard with a Second Front performance curated by Domenico Quaranta, the performance featured "a bi-directional video stream on a 4 metre x 4 metre screen projected live," showing avatars to people and people to avatars. Avatar attendees in Second Life® approached a huge, freestanding portal or doorlike object, seemingly made of wood and ornamented in high baroque style. Festooned around, before, above, and on the portal as the performance ran were naked members of Second Front, adding living dimensions to, becoming part of, and providing reflexive commentary upon the performance space. The piece was intended to remediate Kit Galloway and Sherrie Rabinowitz's *Hole in Space* (1980), a live three-way telecommunication event broadcast simultaneously in New York and Los Angeles.[61] In addition, in front of the projection screen in the Second Life® virtual world, Second Front installed a baroque door mimicking, in virtual reality, Auguste Rodin's monumental portal, *The Gates of Hell* (1900). Those watching the performance of Second Front were probably also reminded of Daniel Canogar's *Clandestinos Madrid* (2006), a public performance in which Canogar projected human forms onto a church front (Iglesia de San Pietro in Montorio).[62]

Reconstructing realities in two worlds, *The Gate* drew a crowd within two kinds of corporate space and was also a reversal of capitalist recuperation, a multiple *fracturing* of worlds that drew attention to the oddness of the everyday—an immediate, affective happening. Creating immediacy in the contact zone between Second Life® and IMAL, and enacting Vaneigem's dream of "one huge instant," the performance nonetheless was highly stylized, recalling both the SI's injunction to planning and rational play and late-twentieth-century art's tendency toward pastiche, popular culture referencing, self-reflexivity, and remediation. However, unlike Freeman's "Imaging Place," which is located at a number of semi-permanent online locations and thus can be caught by a web surfer's dérive, *The Gate* was performed in the public space of a virtual reality "game," while also being to some extent cordoned off in an "art space" on Odyssey that did not interfere with the mundane activities of other Second Life® residents. The piece was not constructed specifically as an SI-inspired event or a "situation" as much as an intermedial performance,

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

but it indicates how difficult it may be *even in virtual space* to construct Situations that move beyond the environments of the intellectual elite and into the spaces of everyday activity. At the same time, the effort of artists to colonize and redefine the space of the aesthetic in Second Life®—to produce incredibly sophisticated media performance art that awakens this space—is quite extraordinary.

End Thoughts

The Situationists understood the nature of play as performance in both its positive and negative sense. Performance is, after all, precisely the logic of the spectacle that reduces thought and collapses time into immediate, affective impression and insatiable desire. According to Debord, this means a fracturing of the world into infinite markets that offer us only iterations of the same: performance within the spectacle includes both the activity of production and the activity of consumption, but since its sole purpose is distraction, it offers no real diversity or depth. Reducing thought and experience to performance and pastiche—especially highly technologized, highly stylized versions—*is* the logic of the spectacle. In the completely technologized world of the Baudrillard simulacrum, it would seem that the Matrix would be complete, the Spectacle triumphant, the aesthetic rendered impotent.

Yet the SI also declared that "we need to work toward flooding the market—even if for the moment merely the intellectual market—with a mass of desires whose realization is not beyond the capacity of one man's present means of action on the material world, but only beyond the capacity of the old social organization."[63] In the tradition of the modernist avant-garde, aesthetics here becomes not a withdrawal from life and politics but their essential medium. The Situationists lobbied for a paradox: using *art* against *representation*, reconstructing a *poesis* out of the signs of the times. The paradox is negotiated by online communities and redoubled because of their space of performance: they must act in the space where somatics have disappeared, where reality consists of the notation of pixels and binary code. Yet, while Lawrence Lessig has shown how computer code can become the tool of totalitarianism, he also attacks this trend by placing his work free online, in the very space that most resents its enunciation. Likewise, cyberartists use code against codification in a WWW performance space. The attack against boredom and generic thinking and the freeing of perception occurs not through the overt claims of politics—understood as just another manifestation of the Spectacle, as symptoms without origins or ends—but through an

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

aesthetic that unearths and awakens the human, voice, thought, and somatics of perception. The counterattack is a situated art praxis in the midst of virtual unreality.

Contemporary avant-gardes cannot ignore a technologized space of performance simultaneously more visible and more invisible than any that has gone before. I have contextualized the cyberarts discussed in this article as a potentially revitalized Situationist effort to reenergize human experience and perception. The effort is not without its dangers, and given their operation in a spectacular medium at some distance from material reality, it is easy for the cyberarts to fall prey to decadence, style, market imperatives, cool chic, or empty but beautiful affect. It is easy for them to forget the people to whom they mean to talk; it may be difficult at times to tell the virtual dancer from the virtual dance. It is equally tempting for critics and web surfers to forget that most of these artists understand virtual space differently, and are not overtly mimicking or updating SI concepts as much as they are reconceptualizing what "space" means in the environments of digital media. Web arts will need constantly to innovate, as the totalitarian and market forces of the web and virtual realities close down on experimentation, critique, and open-source ethics, but also as technology itself evolves. Yet if the Situationist International was correct, and the triumph of the spectacle in material space is inevitable, it may be that détournement, derive, and psychogeography in cyberspace—the conjoining of humanity, art, and cosmopolitan space within the completely artificial and algorithmic "space" of virtual reality—may, ironically, be our last means to glimpse the authentic life. In this regard, we surely need to consider how new media arts both return to, and redefine, the approaches of their materialist ancestors.

UNIVERSITY OF TENNESSEE

NOTES

1 Libero Andreotti and Xavier Costa, eds., *Theory of the Dérive and Other Situationist Writings on the City* (Barcelona: ACTAR: Museu d'Art Contemporani de Barcelona, 1996), 7. Debord defines "the spectacle" in various issues of the SI but in a most sustained manner in *The Society of the Spectacle*, trans. Donald Nicholson-Smith (New York: Zone Books, 1995). The SI membership never numbered more than a dozen or so, and the reality status of the London Psychogeographical Society seems unclear. For a statement about surrealism by the emerging SI itself, see the lead article of issue no. 1 of the *Internationale Situationniste* (June 1958), "The Bitter Victory of Surrealism," http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/si/bitter.html. On the SI in relation to Dada and surrealism, see Sadie Plant, *The Most Radical Gesture: The Situationist International in a Postmodern Age* (London: Routledge, 2002), chap. 2, and Tom McDonough, "Introduction: Ideology and the Situationist Utopia,"in

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Guy Debord and the Situationist International: Texts and Documents, ed. Tom McDonough (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2004), ix–xx. For Situationist and pre-Situationist materials, see Reuben Keehan, et al., Situationist International Online *http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/index.html*; Ken Knabb, ed. and trans., *Situationist International Anthology*, 3rd ed. (Berkeley, CA: Bureau of Public Secrets, 1995), online at http://www.bopsecrets.org/.

2 See Guy Debord, "Introduction to a Critique of Urban Geography," *Les Lévves Nues* 6 (September 1955), repr. in Andreotti and Costa, par. 2, *Theory*, 18–21.

3 See the now classic "Hacker Manifesto," *Wikipedia*, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hacker_manifesto.

4 Debord, "Theory of the Derive," *Internationale Situationniste* 2 (December 1958), repr. in Andreotti and Costa, *Theory*, 23.

5 See Peter Cho, "Cyber Cartography," December 10, 2003, users.design.ucla.edu/~petercho/fall03/cybercartography.pdf.

6 "Report on the Construction of Situations and on the International Situationist Tendency's Conditions of Organization and Action," trans. Ken Knabb at Situationist International Online, http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/si/report.html

7 "Preliminary Problems in Constructing a Situation," *Internationale Situationniste* 1 (June 1958), repr. in Knabb, par. 1 , *Anthology*, 43–46 and at Situationist International Online, http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/si/problems.html.

8 "The Meaning of Decay in Art," par. 13, at Situationist International Online, http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/si/report.html.

9 Debord, "Report."

10 "Contribution to a Situationist Definition of Play." *Internationale Situationniste* 1 (June 1958). trans. Reuben Keehan at Situationist International Online, *http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/*

11 "Détournement as Negation and Prelude" par. 1, at Situationist International Online, http://www.cddc.vt.edu/sionline/si/report.html.

12 Debord, "Contribution."

13 Debord, "Introduction," 20–21.

14 Debord, *Society*, 126.

15 Conflux Festival Site 2009, *http://www.confluxfestival.org/*. Glowlab gallery in New York has been relaunched under the name of its founder Christina Ray, *http://www.christinaray.com/pages/about.*

16 "Stranger than any Pynchon Conspiracy," *http://www.socialfiction.org/snapwalk.html.*

17 See San Precario at *http://www.sanprecario.info/*; see *http://info.interactivist.net/* for a quick summary of these groups. "Precarity" is a neologism combining "precarious" and "proletariat" and signals a state of instability and exploitation of contingent labor in a globalized economy. In Milan, Italy, workers created a "St. Precario" and since 2001 have celebrated February 29 as Precarity Day featuring Situationist-like interventions; this has caught on as a new EuroMayday, a carnivalesque, protest-based network. For information, see *http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Precarity_(Euromayday)*. Beauvais Lyons' "Hokes Archives" at *http://web.utk.edu/~blyons/* and the Yes Men at *http://theyesmen.org/.*

18 "Impossible Communication or Power as Universal Mediation," *The Revolution of Everyday Life, http://library.nothingness.org/articles/SI/en/display_printable/40.*

19 See early treatments of this topic by Domenico Quaranta, *Net Art 1994–1998: La vicenda di Ada'web* (Milan, 2004) and also Maren Hartmann, "Situationist Roaming Online," *http://hypertext.rmit.edu.au/dac/papers/Hartmann.pdf#search=%22Hartmann%2C%20Maren%20situationist%20roaming%20online%22.*; Alt-X, *http://www.altx.com/home.html,* which has been online since 1993 and which features links to two prominent and established net.art sites, Hyper-X and HIAFF.

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

20 George L. Dillon, "Net.art," in *Writing with Images: Toward a Semiotics of the Web*, 5.2, (2003) *http://courses.washington.edu/hypertxt/cgi-bin/12.228.185.206/html/tablesall.html*

21 See D'Urbano's "Couture," *http://www.durbano.de/couture/* and http://www.nr3.de/ for more information about Reichelt's work.

22 *http://hawaiicowboy.free.fr/info.html.* See "Keyboard," *http://www.turbulence.org/Works/keyboard/*. See 'What are you?" at *http://whatareyou.net/*. See the artists' explanatory website, http://marika.incident.net/.

23 In contrast, a number of newer projects take as their subject datamining, server surveillance, and bot mapping: see *http://www.net-art.org/spook*; Marika Dermineur's "Antidatamining" (2007–2009), *http://antidatamining.net/*, done in conjunction with the Rybn Collective, *http://www.rhiz.eu/institution-14996-en.html.*

24 The online interface of DissemiNET as of April 2010 was located at *http://disseminet.walkerart.org/*

25 *http://disseminet.walkerart.org/html/gallerycredits.html*

26 *http://www.walkerart.org/archive/D/B17371F39382358D6164.htm.*

27 Beth Stryker, "Interview," *http://www.walkerart.org/archive/7/B57371B81DB88C1A6169.htm.*

28 Equally politicized online projects by Korean artist Rho Jae Oon: "3 Open Up" is one section of a trilogy presenting slow-moving, digitalized scenes depicting lived geography. For some time, these works were available online at *www.vimalaki.net*; the site is now offline, and one wonders if the current political situation has intervened.

29 N. Katherine Hayles, *Electronic Literature: New Horizons for the Literary* (Notre Dame, IN: Univ. of Notre Dame Press, 2008), 128.

30 Jessica Pressman, "The Strategy of Digital Modernism: Young-Hae Chang Heavy Industries's *Dakota*," *Modern Fiction Studies* 54, no. 2 (2008): 310–11.

31 Petra Heck, "Interview with Young-Hae Chang Heavy Industries," nettime-l, *http://www.mail-archive.com/nettime-l@kein.org/msg01062.html.*

32 Quoted in interview with Thom Swiss, "Distance, Homelessness, Anonymity, Insignificance," *Iowa Review Web* (2002), www.uiowa.edu/~iareview/tirweb/feature/younghae/interview.html.

33 See, for example, the Histories of Internet Art: Fictions and Factions site, available through Alt-X, *http://art.colorado.edu/hiaff/home.htm*, and "Introduction to net.art" at *http://www.easylife.org/netart/*. Turbulence.org is located at *http://www.turbulence.org/about/about.html.* The Electronic Literature Organization is located at *http://www.eliterature.org/.*

34 This was recognized by the Brooklyn, NY Conflux Festival in September, 2007 (seehttp://sndrv.nl/slwalkietalkie). In that annual celebration of psychogeography, attendees were given free walkie-talkies that connected visually to an avatar in Second Life®; while one walked the streets of New York, the other walked simultaneously in Second Life®—extending the boundaries of psychogeography itself.

35 The Second Life® official site is located at *http://secondlife.com.*

36 For a full ethnographic study of the communities in Second Life® see Tom Boellstorff, *Coming of Age in* Second Life®*: An Anthroplogist Explores the Virtually Human* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton Univ. Press, 2008).

37 See Bryan Carter's bio, *http://glsconference.org/2006/pop/carterb.htm.*

38 Stephan Doesinger, ed. *Space Between People: How the Virtual Changes Physical Architecture* (Munich: Prestel, 2008), 14.

39 Italo Calvino, *Invisible Cities* (New York: Harvest Books, 1978).

40 Gilles Ivain,"Formulary for a New Urbanism," *International Situationiste* 1 (June 1958), repr. in Andreotti and Costa, *Theory*, 14–17.

41 At *http://www.virtual-art-initiative.org/Virtual_Art_Initiative/index.html.* Virtual Arts Initiative is directed by Gary Zabel, a member of the University of Massachusetts at Boston's

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Philosophy Department since 1989. The Initiative maintains four sims in Second Life®: Caerleon Isle, an artists collaborative space; New Caerleon, an experimental university; and Caerleon Art Collective and Caerleon Art Collective 2, both artists' colonies. Activities include workshops, lecture series, and seminars as well as active installations and collective projects. Odyssey Art Simulator, *http://odysseyart.ning.com* was created by Pacino Hercules and Sugar Seville (SL™ avatar names) and as of April 2010 was managed by Artistic Director Fau Ferdinand with codirector lizsolo Mathilde, both members of The Second Front, and is funded by Dynamis Corporation.

42 "Seventeen Unsung Songs" is featured in Doesinger, *Space Between People*, 88–89.

43 Dr. Lisa Dethridge (Lisa Dapto), "Seventeen Unsung Songs," *http://yamanakanash.net/secondlife/unsung_songs.html*

44 Email with the artist, May 3, 2010. Nash also directed me to Wikipedia, "Post-Convergent," http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Post-convergent.

45 Imaging Place in Second Life®, SLurl (111, 141, 64) and online at *http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/imaging_place/imaging-placeSL/index.html.* The Florida Research Ensemble, *http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/imaging_place/about/research_ensembles/fre.html.*

46 *http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/imaging_place/imaging_place.html.* See Podcast for "Imaging Place,"at http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/podcast/ImagingPlace_2008/

47 Email in response to author questions, posted at "Imaging Beijing" (blog), January 17, 2008.

48 At *http://pages.emerson.edu/Faculty/J/John_Craig_Freeman/*

49 Debord, *Society*, 120.

50 Email to author, posted at "Imaging Place" blog, January 17, 2008.

51 *http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/imaging_place/about/projects/u_s_mex/index.html*

52 *http://institute.emerson.edu/vma/faculty/john_craig_freeman/imaging_place/about/projects/u_s_mex/index.html*

53 *http://arsvirtua.com/about.php.*

54 For reports on the bombing, see News.com.au, *http://www.news.com.au/entertainment/story/0,23663,21780235-7486,00.html.* In Second Life®, "griefing" is the term used to describe harrassment, sabotage, acts of violence, or vandalism at any island site, and extreme griefing is cause for expulsion.

55 "The Second Front," *http://www.secondfront.org/index.html#.* Original members of the group were Wirxli FlimFlam/Jeremy O. Turner; Gazira Babelli; Man Michinaga/Patrick Lichty; Tran Spire/Doug Jarvis; Penny Leong Browne; Liz Solo; Great Escape/Scott Kildall. Today the group is comprised of members Gazira Babeli; Fau Ferdinand/Yael Gilks; Great Escape/Scott Kindall; Bibbe Oh/Bibbe Hansen; lizsolo Mathilde/Liz Solo; Man Michinaga/Patrick Lichty; and Tran Spire/Doug Jarvis. Wirxli FlimFlam committed avatar suicide for love of another avatar in a SL performance piece on Valentine's Day 2010.

56 At http://slfront.blogspot.com/. It should be noted that Second Life® has made it clear that it may log user chat and activities inworld, and it has increasingly instituted policies policing residents inworld behavior (such as "age play") in the interest of community standards and responsible play, a policy sometimes seemingly counter to its ethic of resident-constructed communities on an open-source model. See, for example, Linden's statement on its collection of information, http://secondlife.com/corporate/privacy.php?lang=en-US#privacy1.

57 http://slfront.blogspot.com/2007/08/inter-access-summer-workshop.html

58 The group has stated its ties to Fluxus in a number of public interviews and blogsites. In addition, the group members have professional and personal ties to Fluxus. Patrick

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Lichty, a professor at Columbia College, Chicago, is editor-in-chief of *Intelligent Agent*, an electronic arts/culture journal based in New York City and is an animator for the activist group The Yes Men, an internationally recognized performance group that stages public hoaxes embedding political commentary (see *http://theyesmen.org/*). As her webpage notes, Bibbe Hansen is the daughter of Al Hansen of Fluxus, worked with Andy Warhol and Jonas Mekas, and appeared in Warhol's films. Babeli was part of the initial launch of Odyssey Art and is accruing international gallery and exhibition recognition; Simulator Liz Solo and Scott Kindall are practicing artists in multiple media.

59 The term "remediation" became mainstream with the publication of Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin's *Remediation: Understanding New Media* (Boston, MA: MIT Press, 2000).

60 Discussion and pictures of *The Gate* performance can be viewed at Quaranta's archived site "Spawn of the Surreal," *http://spawnofthesurreal.blogspot.com/search?updated-min=2007-01-01T00%3A00%3A00%2B01%3A00&updated-max=2008-01-01T00%3A00%3A00%2B01%3A00&max-results=22*

61 Recently "Hole in Space" was exhibited as an installation at The San Francisco Museum of Modern Art as part of The Art of Participation: 1950 to Now, Nov. 2008–Feb 2009. Pictures of the original event are in the museum catalog.

62 See pictures of Canogar's piece at http://www.danielcanogar.com/ and http://www.seacex.es/Spanish/Activities/Activity_Library/Paginas/ACTIVITY_171_1.aspx?vid=1_1_171_508

63 Debord, "Introduction," in Andreotti and Costa, *Theory*, 19.

This content downloaded from
160.39.69.129 on Tue, 27 Oct 2026 15:57:55 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms